

Electronics hobbyists were turning towards digitising electronics, but were not happy with the inflexible kits available—and their low power.



Computing started becoming personal yet affordable for hobbyists with the arrival of the Altair

The Altair plugged both shortcomings—it had enough power, and had a flexible system open to all sorts of experiments. The Altair 8800 was based on the 8080, and had 256 bytes of standard RAM. Hobbyists were eager to buy the Altair even at a price nearing \$500 (Rs 70,000 today). Then the Altair 8800 was made available with different memory boards: 1 KB, 2KB, and so on up to 64 KB. Then the included 8-inch floppy drive triggered the interest of more hobbyists.

Roberts had received a letter from Bill Gates and Paul Allen from Boston to buy their BASIC programming language for the Altair machines. Gaining the interest of Roberts, the duo worked on a simulator for the 8080 on a PDP-10 minicomputer, and the first run displayed “Altair Basic” using paper tape! MITS was sold out to Pertec in 1977, and Pertec continued producing the Altair through 1978.

September: The Alto

At Xerox PARC, a prototype of the world’s first What-You-See-Is-What-You-Get personal computer called the Alto was demonstrated. The Alto had a GUI, a bit-mapped display, and a commercial mouse as an input device. It was a research tool, not a commercial product; it offered features like menus and icons, linking to a local area network, and the storing of files. It was a small minicomputer and was termed a personal com-



Computing became personal when the first personal computer—the Alto (not for commercial purposes)—was exhibited